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#9 Neighborhood Demographics

Before I get into my findings from the Opportunity Atlas, I want to highlight some findings from my last interview. Jan Loux, the Vice-Chair of the Peaceful Valley Neighborhood Council had some very intriguing insight when it comes to the neighborhood demographic. The following takeaways will aid me in deeper research.

1. Peaceful Valley has a very high education level but relatively low income level. This fact speaks volumes of the neighborhood's residents. Ms. Loux explained that over the years Peaceful Valley has developed a reputation as an inexpensive refuge for artists and musicians. It has a counterculture fueled by low rents and an excellent location.
2. The enclave has a very stable population. Because of the lack of space, the population of Peaceful Valley has stagnated. Additionally, the process of gentrification has been traded for low-income infill. Peaceful valley has fended off the construction of large apartment buildings thus far. Ms. Loux was hugely grateful for this. The Peaceful Valley Neighborhood Council is presently working towards getting permits granted to safeguard the open spaces that remain.
3. Homelessness has always been a big issue in the Valley. Up until 1893, the neighborhood was previously referred to as 'Poverty Flats'. Poverty Flats was a home for squatters and run down shacks. It's appeal mainly stems from its location. The area was close to town and was attractive to poor immigrants and remains attractive to the homeless in the present.

After using the Opportunity Atlas, a few things stood out to me. These findings mirror the aforementioned information that Ms. Loux provided.

1. Around 86% of the neighborhood has graduated highschool. Moreover, almost 45% of the neighborhood has gone to college. These numbers are staggering considering that the median household income of residents in 2016 was in the 11th percentile. How is it that Peaceful Valley claims some of the highest poverty rates? 52% of individuals with a bachelor's degree or higher are currently living below the poverty line. It's safe to say that this is a lifestyle decision. I think that unmaterialistic is a good word to describe a peaceful valley resident.
2. The population of Peaceful Valley hasn't increased since 2016. However, the population density of the neighborhood is average. The neighborhood simply can't handle a large influx of people. I suspect that the population of Peaceful Valley will remain around 4,000 for the years to come. The historical significance of the neighborhood is definitely something worth preserving.
3. The neighborhood is the 91st percentile for single parents. 65% of parents in the community are alone. Why is this the case? At this point in my research I had to reach out and borrow some statistics from another database. I discovered that around 40% of the married population is divorced, and an additional 13% is widowed. I spent a couple hours trying to figure out why this was the case. But with no luck.